

Figure 3.9 *Shahr-i Zohak (fifth–thirteenth century), general view, triangular plateau with fortifications, from south. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

Turks in the sixth century and the consequent shifting of political alliances, a later phase of building apparently took place outside the core area of Bamiyan in the secondary valleys. Nevertheless, virtually all complexes datable to the pre-Islamic centuries shared broad characteristics.[46] It should also be emphasized that, while it is tempting to assign an *exclusively* military function to the complexes atop Bamiyan's rocky promontories – an interpretation seemingly justified by the ongoing politico-military power-plays in the region – close examination of the remains themselves indicates that their uses varied, and that they acquired defensive and other military functions only over time.[47]

Shahr-i Zuhak and other complexes consisted of brick walls atop footings of stone, or stone-rubble masonry (Figure 3.9) – a building method also encountered in central through southern Ghur. Most complexes had corner towers or bastions with circular or angular plans (Figures 3.9 and 3.10), their elevations exhibiting equally familiar geometric patterns. But